

documents and spreadsheets. My real work (as I liked to think of it) was done in Fedora.

Most of the people in our team used Putty sessions for their day-to-day work. I used XTerms, with logging enabled, to SSH into machines in different parts of the country. I never came physically close to any of the machines I worked on.

I constructed the scripting infrastructure to support the automated installation of software. Since the Fedora environment was reasonably similar to the Solaris environments I was building, I could develop and test the scripts on my machine prior to deployment on the customer's servers. I'm not sure it would have been possible in a Microsoft environment. It certainly would not have been as quick and easy.

Where others could build one or two machines concurrently, I could easily build six or more.

Evaluation

When I worked in the Fedora environment, I was in paradise. Given that I'd never worked with VirtualBox previously, it was reasonably easy to install and use. If you want to use the free version, there were some silly restrictions about the USB about three years ago—things may have changed by now.

There were two big issues that would discourage me from using VirtualBox ever again. The first was an upgrade; the second was to do with snapshots.

At the outset, let me apologise for not having every last detail at hand. In both cases, at the time, the impact horrified me; my focus was on restoring service, not documenting for posterity. I realise that I'm being a bit unfair to VirtualBox, but I can assure you that the impressions stay with me long after the details have dimmed.

Most products these days nag you about upgrading to the latest version. That's understandable, especially if your philosophy is 'release early, release often'. Many products even come configured to upgrade themselves automatically. How anyone can allow themselves to be held hostage like that is beyond me.

VirtualBox was not configured to upgrade itself. However, after I'd been using it for a month or two, it did invite me to upgrade. I can't remember what the inducement was, but I fell for it. And regretted it. Yet, lived to tell the tale.

I'm not particularly proud of my part in the debacle. Looking back, I believe I could have been more cautious. I guess I thought that since the mod was only a point rev, and not a major revision, the difference could not be too dramatic. Bear in mind that this was not an alpha release, or a beta test; nor even an RC (Release Candidate) but a proper release.

I upgraded. Something didn't work. A search revealed that others had the same problem. I'm sorry, but I don't recall the details; perhaps something to do with networking.

I reverted to the previous version, losing very little other than perhaps some time.

The second issue was scarier. I am compulsive about

taking back-ups of everything I do. VirtualBox (along with many VMs) has the concept of snapshots. So, from time to time, I took VirtualBox snapshots. Now, I admit I might have contributed to the problem. It seems that my mental models of snapshots did not match the way VirtualBox worked. I thought taking a snapshot was like taking a back-up.

I was a little concerned at the rate at which I was proliferating snapshots. And I was disconcerted at the way the snapshots seemed to be descending a tree. I felt that they ought to be more like files in a directory; VirtualBox represented them like one directory under another.

I read everything I could find. I gained the impression that all the information for the current state of the VM was located in the latest snapshot; that I could delete earlier snapshots. I might not have recalled these details accurately.

I deleted one or two snapshots. When I restarted the VM, I discovered that I had gone back in time by about a month! I was horrified.

I've talked about the Principle of Least Surprise in the past. I've used a lot of software over many years. I cannot recall a time I was as unpleasantly surprised as this.

I was lucky on two counts. First, the Fedora environment was largely a platform from which to reach other computers. From that perspective, all I lost was the occasional tweaks that I made to that environment.

Most VMs have a mechanism to share data between the host and the client. I had always made a point of copying development work out of the VM onto the XP disk. So, again, I didn't lose a lot.

But both incidents resulted in some loss, and might have resulted in far more.

The second time: Linux/Vmware Player/MS Windows

I was at another company, filling in for one person who had left, and another, Kevin, who was going on long service leave for three months. Most of the staff ran XP on their PCs. Kevin was my soul brother: he ran Linux (Ubuntu) with a copy of XP running inside a Vmware Player. This makes eminently more sense to me than the alternatives. Very kindly, he bequeathed me his PC in his absence.

This time I did not have to install anything—it had all been set up for me.

And instead of building Solaris servers, this time, I was building servers as VMs under Vmware vCenter. The primary build involved filling in forms in a browser, so the task could have been performed on any platform. But *sysadmin* involves more than just filling forms; for those activities, I could work on the native Ubuntu or, where necessary, I could SSH into various servers.

Evaluation

For my taste, the native Linux with XP in a VM was a more natural and comfortable environment. At home, I run both